Reflexive AI

World Café facilitation · volunteer-run

In-company World Café

A facilitation guide for running a World Café about reflexive AI in your organization.

// WHY THIS WORLD CAFÉ

Uncover how your organization can use AI in a human-centered manner.

It gathers evidence for a governance framework — and gives people in your organization space to discuss what human-centered AI means for them.

Face-to-face, ≈100–120 minutes

Group discussions and individual reflection, with clear improvement actions at the end.

15–25 participants, 5 topics

A World Café across five stations, each moderated by a host.

PURPOSE OF THE STUDY

Help us uncover how organizations can use AI in a human-centered, responsible manner.

A collaborative action research project run by volunteering academics and professionals, and overseen by a 10-member peer review board.

reflexiveai.org · info@reflexiveai.org

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About this guide

Thank you for contributing to the Reflexive AI Research Initiative. We are grateful for your time and effort.

This facilitation guide helps you run a World Café about reflexive AI in your organization. It provides invaluable insights for our research initiative to answer the research question "*How can organizations leverage the power of artificial intelligence in a manner that is human-centered? What principles, rules, norms, interventions, processes and strategies are needed to achieve this? How can this be monitored?*". It also provides a good opportunity for people in your organization to reflect on what this means for them.

The World Café typically takes 100–120 minutes. We assume, and recommend, a face-to-face setting with 15–25 participants. If you have fewer participants, the World Café uses fewer stations (see further down). Because the World Café is part of a scientific study, it is important to:

- **Coordinate with our research team** at info@reflexiveai.org to register your session, ensure rigor and informed consent. Please do this before you invite participants. Otherwise we can not use your outcomes.
- Ensure **all participants understand** they are taking part in a scientific study, and that the (anonymous) results from the discussions will be shared with the research team.
- Data collection relies on **written materials** only, so instruct participants to write clearly.
- **Do not bias participants** by pushing them in a certain direction (i.e. “AI is great” or “AI is terrible”).
- **Do not modify the format** unless absolutely necessary. Deviations may risk making the data unusable for the initiative due to methodological inconsistencies.

How to prepare

How to invite people

- Clarify the aim of the World Café: to uncover how organizations can use AI in a human-centered way. Keep your invitation free from personal beliefs or bias.
- For the best outcomes, maximize the number of people with decision-making authority around AI.
- Emphasize that the discussion is part of a scientific study. Anonymized insights will be shared with the research initiative.

An example invitation is: *“Artificial intelligence (AI) is changing our work and workplaces in many ways. I invite you to a 120-minute World Café where we think about how our organization can use AI in a human-centered manner. What is important when using AI in order to benefit from it while doing so in a way that improves our work experience and work enjoyment? This is part of a global research initiative, and our anonymous results will be shared with them. The questions we tackle will also help our own thinking about this in our organization. Your views, perspective and contribution are highly appreciated.”.*

Materials

- Print the station topics (5 total).
- Print the station host protocol (5 total, one for each host).
- Print the working definition for human-centered AI (1 total).
- Print the informed consent forms (1 per participant, including facilitators).
- Bring empty flip charts or whiteboards (5 with some extra).
- Bring stickies, markers and pens.
- A timer is useful to track time. A buzzer or tingsha bell is useful to get attention.
- Optionally, bring snacks and drinks for a relaxed atmosphere.

Practical preparation

- Create five stations for the "World Café" (or 3 if you have fewer than 15 participants). This could be five tables with 4–6 chairs, five flipcharts or whiteboards. Ensure there is one topic sheet and one station host protocol at each station. Add markers, stickies, snacks and drinks.
- Ideally, pick participants upfront to act as the five station hosts (for "World Café") and ensure they've read the station host protocol.

 5 min

Step 1. Welcome

Welcome the participants to the World Café. Thank them for making time to contribute. Introduce yourself.

Introduce the topic for this World Café: to explore what human-centered AI use looks like in your organization, and what can be done to ensure it.

It is important to keep this part short and free of bias. The next step is an opening exercise to get everyone's thinking started.

 5 min

Step 2. Informed Consent

In this step, participants and the facilitators give their consent to participate in a scientific study. Good research requires informed consent at the start.

Steps

- Ask all participants and facilitators to complete the informed consent form. If a person does not wish to consent, this is perfectly fine. However, they cannot continue participating in the session.
- Collect the forms.

20 min

Step 3. Impromptu Networking

We begin the session with an opener to help participants get their thinking started about human-centered AI, and build on each other.

Steps

- **1 min** Ask *"What does human-centered AI look like for you? How does this relate to your work or this organization?"*. Give participants 1 minute to reflect on this in silence.
- **4 min** Ask participants to form pairs and take 4 minutes to share their views. With an uneven number of participants, there will be one group of three.
- **4 min** Ask participants to form new pairs, and take 4 minutes to share their views and build on the previous round.
- **4 min** Ask participants to form new pairs, and take 4 minutes to share their views and build on the previous round.
- **2 min** In their current pair, ask participants to take a sticky or index card and write down how they define human-centered AI.
- **4 min** With the whole group, ask the pairs to share some of their definitions. Close by noting that these reflections provide the basis for the next step, the World Café.
- **1 min** Clarify that one aim of this initiative is to develop a good definition for Human-Centered AI. Present the **incomplete working definition** (PDF). In this definition, AI usage in organizations is human-centered when it "*1) is not used in a manner that harms other living beings emotionally, physically or financially, 2) prioritizes human needs and autonomy in design and application, 3) makes outcomes transparent, interpretable and verifiable, 4) is inclusive and supports continuous learning and 5) minimizes environmental impact through energy efficiency and substainable practices.*".
- **collect** The stickies or index cards with definitions (i.e. on a wall, on the floor or with you).

60 min

Step 4: World Café

We use World Café as the primary format for the focus groups. We assume 15–25 participants. If you have fewer participants, limit to three stations (topics 1, 4, 5). In this format, each participant discusses 3 out of 5 topics in small groups at different stations, each moderated by a host. So with five stations, you have five hosts.

How to run

- Introduce the aim: to engage in multiple rounds of small-group discussions around 5 topics, each at a different station, and capture the output on sheets.
- Explain the general format. Participants will distribute evenly across the stations. There, a neutral host facilitates a small-group discussion and records insights on a sheet. After 15 minutes, a new round starts and participants move to another station and a new topic.
- Invite participants to distribute evenly across the stations. If you did not pick hosts upfront, ask each small group to choose one of their own to act as host. The hosts facilitate and moderate the discussion, asking open questions while withholding their own views and opinions. Ensure that each group familiarizes themselves with the station host protocol.
- **15 min** Begin round 1 (“Discussion”). Invite the participants at each table to discuss their topic openly and collaboratively for 15 minutes. The hosts moderate the discussion, write down group insights and ensure that the host protocol is followed. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **15 min** Begin round 2 (“Discussion”). Ask the participants to redistribute evenly across the stations, picking a station at random that they have not already visited. Invite the participants to discuss their new topic with the station host, who continues moderating the discussion and adding insights to the sheet. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **15 min** Begin round 3 (“Discussion”). Ask the participants to redistribute evenly across the stations, picking a station at random that they have not already visited. Invite the participants to discuss their new topic with the station host, who continues moderating the discussion and adding insights to the sheet. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **10 min** Bring everyone together and ensure they have a marker or dot vote stickers in hand. Ask all participants - including the hosts - to walk the five stations in silence so as not to bias each other. At each station, participants distribute three dots across the stickies with the ideas or insights they **deem most important for their organization**. So three dots per station per participant. If stickies are unclear, participants skip them and focus on those that are clear. Continue when all participants have voted.
- **collect** The posters created at each station (with dot votes) and any notes by the hosts.

Station topics

1. **What human-centered AI looks like:** What should human-centered AI look like in your organization? What results or outcomes would you see?
2. **When AI helps:** How has AI been used in your organization in a manner that improved the work experience or work enjoyment of employees?
3. **When AI gets in the way:** What are examples in your organization where the use of AI was not human-centered, or where could you see it easily sliding down that path?
4. **Rules & procedures:** What procedures, rules or processes should be implemented to ensure human-centered AI in your organization?
5. **Measurement & auditing:** What could be measured, tracked or audited to ensure that the way your organization uses AI is human-centered?

15 min

Step 5: 15% Solutions

Following the discussions about human-centered AI in the previous rounds, we now translate insights into practical action. We use the concept of "15% Solutions" where we assume 85% of what we want to change is outside our control, so lets focus on the 15% that is within control.

How to run

- Ensure all participants have access to empty index cards or stickies, and have a pen at hand.
- **3 min** Invite participants to silently and individually reflect on the question *"Based on what we learned, what is an action you can take in this organization when it comes to human-centered AI? Where do you have autonomy and the resources to act?"*.
- **2 min** Ask participants to write down their action(s).
- **4 min** Invite participants to form groups of 2–3 to coach each other to make actions more doable.
- **2 min** Ask participants to write the refined action clearly on a sticky or index card, and put them on an empty flip in front of the group. When the world cafe concludes, they can take their cards with them.
- **3 min** With the whole group, ask for some people who would like to share their action.
- **collect** A clear picture of the index cards or stickies with actions.

5 min

Step 6: Closing

Close the session by thanking everyone for their time, and the station hosts for their gracious facilitation. Reiterate that the anonymous results will be shared with the research initiative, and that research updates will be made available on reflexiveai.org.

We recommend going through this checklist:

- **collect** Filled-in informed consent forms for every participant and facilitator.
- **collect** The index cards or stickies with definitions (from "Impromptu Networking").
- **collect** The posters from each station (from "World Café") with stickies & dot votes, and host notes.
- **collect** A clear picture of the poster with the index cards or stickies with actions (from "15% Solutions").

Step 7: Send results to us

When you've completed the focus group, please share the following with us to contribute to the research:

- Clear pictures of the station sheets, including dot votes, and the poster with 15% Solutions. Please remove or blur people's names and company-sensitive information (if any).
- A brief review by you and any other facilitators as to how the session went. What worked? What did not work? Where did you observe tension or friction?
- Scans or pictures of filled-in informed consent forms for all participants and the facilitators. Unfortunately, we cannot process *any* data without informed consent.
- Send the materials to info@reflexiveai.org.